

Emotional approach

“Active movement toward, rather than away from, a stressful or emotional encounter”.

Emotional avoidance: Active movement away from, rather than toward, a stressful or emotional encounter.

This distinction between emotional approach and emotional avoidance is supported by the existence of two neurobiological systems that govern approach (i.e., appetitive) and avoidance behavior.

- Behavioral activation system
- Behavioral inhibition system

The **behavioral activation system** regulates our appetitive motivation, which helps us realize emotional or behavioral rewards,

The **behavioral inhibition system** functions to help us avoid negative events and punishment (Depue, 1996).

Processes

Stanton, Kirk, Cameron, and Danoff-Burg (2000) identified two related but distinct processes involved in approach-oriented emotion-focused coping:

- Emotional processing
- Emotional expression

Emotional processing, or attempts to understand emotions.

i.e, I realize that my feelings are valid and important.

Emotional expression, or free and intentional displays of feeling.

i.e, I feel free to express my emotions.

- Emotional approach coping involves the **conscious** use of emotional expression and processing to better deal with a stressful situation.
- Emotion-focused coping was associated with largely maladaptive outcomes while emotional processing and expression was demonstrated to be beneficial.

Mechanisms

1. Goal identification and pursuit

The effects of emotional approach coping could be the result of identifying goals, understanding barriers to achieving those goals, and finding new pathways to achieve them. Emotional

expression and processing could help individual direct attention to identify the most important goals in their lives.

2. Habituation to the stressor and cognitive appraisal

The effects of emotional approach coping could also be due to exposure to stressful stimuli when actively processing and expressing emotions. The repeated exposure to the stressor could result in physiological [habituation](#). Repeated exposure to a stressor through emotional expression and processing could also lead to [cognitive reappraisal](#) of the stressor and related [self-affirmations](#).

3. Affect labeling

The process of labeling the emotions (i.e., putting them into words) may lessen the intensity of the emotional experience. Studies have shown the process of affective labeling leads to decreases in brain regions such as the [amygdala](#) and increases in activation of the [prefrontal cortex](#), possibly indicating beneficial emotion regulation

4. Regulation of social environment

The use of emotional approach coping may signal to the social environment that an individual is in need of support. The responsiveness of the social environment will determine the adaptiveness of emotional approach coping. Emotional expression that is met with empathetic concern may lead to better adjustment than emotional expression met by rejection. Some evidence from the research suggests this could be a potential mechanism. For women with breast cancer who perceive their social environment to be highly receptive, coping through emotional expression predicts improved quality of life.